DISCUSSION PAPER

# Artist Directory

## Should We Build It? What Should It Look Like?

Juergen & Scott · April 2026

5 Research Investigations | 200+ Citations | Idea 001

THE ORIGINAL PROPOSAL

# Scott's Pitch

> *"Create a private, exclusive, curated online artist gallery/directory powered by our database featuring 1000+ artists anyone can view, discover and connect with artists for a nominal fee."*

**SUBSCRIBERS**

**1,000**

@ $25/mo ($250/yr)

**ARTISTS**

**1,000**

@ $10/mo ($100/yr)

**PROJECTED REVENUE**

**$350K**

annual target

The data asset: 1,000+ artists and 8,000+ artworks with AI-enriched profiles, classifications, tags, and dimensions

RESEARCH APPROACH

# How We Investigated This

| 5 | 200+ | 15+ |
|---|---|---|
| parallel deep-research investigations | web citations analyzed | art platforms and competitors benchmarked |

Investigation 1 — Market viability: do paid artist directories work?

Investigation 2 — Freemium models: what to show, what to gate

Investigation 3 — Market validation: how to test before building

Investigation 4 — Artist value proposition: what artists actually need

Investigation 5 — B2B opportunity: who would pay real money?

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

# Five Key Findings

1. **Scott's specific revenue model faces strong headwinds.** No successful art platform charges consumers to browse. At 1,000 artists, the database is too small to justify a subscription.

2. **The underlying idea has real merit — with a different structure.** Freemium with gated connection features aligns with every successful platform's approach.

3. **The strongest revenue opportunity is B2B.** Interior designers and art consultants would pay $300-500/month. Real budgets, real pain points.

4. **Exhibition auto-matching is a greenfield opportunity.** No platform does AI-powered matching of artists to open calls. The enriched data already exists for this.

5. **Even if revenue never materializes, it's a lead generation engine** — driving submissions, segmented contacts, grant applications, and ecosystem growth.

MARKET REALITY

# Browsing Is Free

## Every major art platform offers free discovery

| Platform | Who Pays | Pricing | Browse |
|---|---|---|---|
| Artsy | Galleries: $200-3K+/mo | Subscriptions + commissions | FREE |
| Saatchi Art | Artists: 40% commission | Pure commission | FREE |
| Singulart | Artists: 45-50% commission | Commission + tiers | FREE |
| Artnet | Data subscribers: ~$29+/mo | Data + advertising | FREE |
| Artwork Archive | Artists: $6-139/mo | SaaS for artists | NONE |

What IS paywalled successfully: market data and analytics (Artnet, ArtFacts) — intelligence *about* art, not access to *view* art. Beowolff Capital acquired Artnet for ~$73.7M and took a controlling stake in Artsy in 2025 — consolidation is around data + marketplace, not directories.

REVENUE PATHWAYS

# Different Roads to $350K

| Scenario | Year 1 | Year 2 | Assumptions |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Scott's Original Model** | **$350K** | $350K+ | 1,000 subs + 1,000 artists |
| **Optimistic Freemium** | **$50-80K** | $200-300K | B2B + artist pro, aggressive growth |
| **Realistic Freemium** | **$18-40K** | $80-150K | Modest conversion, organic growth |
| **Lead Gen Only** | **$0** | $0 | Value via submissions, grants, partners |

The opportunity: $350K is achievable — the research points to B2B channels, exhibition matching, and curated positioning as faster paths than consumer subscriptions alone. The rest of this deck explores how we might get there by playing to our unique strengths.

THE MODEL THAT WORKS

# Gate Connection, Not Content

Show the art freely. Charge for contact and tools.

| Tier | Price | What's Included |
|---|---|---|
| **Public Browse** | Free | All artworks, basic search, artist names, truncated bios |
| **Free Account** | Free (email) | 5 wishlists, follow 20 artists, full bios |
| **Collector Premium** | $9.99/mo | Direct messaging, unlimited saves, price alerts, advanced filters |
| **Artist Free** | Free | Profile + uploads, basic analytics, receive inquiries |
| **Artist Pro** | $19.99/mo | Exhibition matching, lead CRM, advanced analytics, SEO |
| **Institutional** | $299/mo | Database access, bulk search, API, multi-user |

Key insight: Direct messaging/artist contact is the #1 conversion driver — 50-65% of paying users cite it as primary reason to subscribe.

ARTIST ECONOMICS

# What Artists Actually Spend

## $30-100/month fragmented across 4+ tools

**PORTFOLIO HOSTING**
**$8-26**
Format, Cargo, Squarespace

**SUBMISSIONS**
**$17-42**
CaFE, Submittable fees

**SOCIAL MEDIA**
**$5-43**
Buffer, Later, freelancers

**INVENTORY**
**$9-42**
Artwork Archive

The consolidation opportunity: Artists pay $200-500+/year on submission fees alone — with zero matching intelligence. 40% feel unconfident in self-promotion. A platform that consolidates discovery, analytics, and exhibition matching replaces multiple tools.

POSITIONING

# Curated, Not Commodified

## This is the opposite of mass-market art

### Mass Market

Society6, Redbubble, Fine Art America — $12.96B market, projected $103B by 2034. Decor-driven, trend-driven, seasonally replaced. No artist relationship. No story.

### What We're Building

1,000-2,000 vetted, real artists with AI-enriched profiles. Conversation pieces, not filler. Local artists designers can visit, commission, and build relationships with.

**95%**
of Gen Z collectors cite emotional connection as primary purchase motivation

**60%**
specifically want to support underrepresented voices

**63%**
of collectors bought directly from artists in 2024-25 (2x from 2022)

**180K**
US interior designers served by only ~5,000 galleries

The small database is the feature, not the bug. 1,000 curated artists signals quality. Arterial's DNA — Not Real Art, Arthouse TV, Artsville, Sugar Press — already embodies supporting real, local, underrepresented artists. This is not a pivot; it's who we are.

THE REAL OPPORTUNITY

# B2B: Interior Designers & Art Consultants

WILLINGNESS TO PAY

**$300-500**

per month

GLOBAL MARKET

**$128B**

interior design services

US DESIGN FIRMS

**10-15K**

with sufficient scale

⚠ The pain point: When a designer needs 12 paintings at 36"x48" with specific color palettes for a hotel corridor, they spend 20-30 hours manually browsing with no multi-dimensional filtering. Our data has exactly what they need: dimensions, medium, subject, tags — searchable attributes no other emerging-artist platform offers.

B2B SEGMENTS

# Ranked by Fit and Revenue Potential

| # | Segment | Pain Point | Asset Fit | Annual Rev |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Interior designers + consultants | Manual sourcing is painful | STRONG | $150-350K |
| 2 | Small-to-mid galleries | Oversupply, not undersupply | STRONG | $80-200K |
| 3 | Independent curators | Finding artists for themed shows | STRONG | $40-100K |
| 4 | Corporate art programs | Buy through intermediaries | MEDIUM | $45-100K |
| 5 | Arts education | Rigid budgets, long cycles | STRONG | $100-300K (3+ yr) |

COMPETITIVE POSITIONING

# What Nobody Else Combines

### AI-Enriched Discovery

Not just portfolio dumps — AI-researched profiles, validated citations, classified artworks

### Multi-Dimensional Search

Dimensions, medium, subject, tags, color — visual attributes no other emerging-artist platform offers

### Emerging/Mid-Career Focus

Existing platforms skew established. This serves the underserved middle of the market.

### 501(c)(3) Trust Factor

Grant eligibility, tax advantages, "built to serve artists, not extract from them"

THE FLOOR CASE

# Even If Nobody Pays

## The platform has substantial value as a lead generation engine

### Exhibition Submissions

Every browser who sees "Submit to our next exhibition" is a warm lead for NRA, Artsville, and partners

### Segmented Contacts

Artist vs. curator vs. collector — transforms an undifferentiated list into a multi-purpose asset

### Grant Leverage

5,000+ users strengthens every NEA, Knight Foundation, and Bloomberg application

B2B ARTS CPL

**$300-500** per lead

SEGMENTED LIST VALUE

**$2-5K** per year

GRANT APPLICATION LIFT

**$10-100K** NEA alone

GROWTH MILESTONES

# What Success Looks Like

### Month 3

500+ registered users · clear segment breakdown · engagement data to prioritize features

### Month 6

50+ paying users across tiers · 2-3 institutional/B2B customers · measurable lift in exhibition submissions

### Month 12

200+ paying users · $3-5K MRR · 2,000+ registered users · at least one grant citing platform data

### Month 18+

$8-15K MRR · 5,000+ registered users · B2B pipeline generating $50K+ ARR

OPPORTUNITIES BEYOND DISCOVERY

# Exhibition Auto-Matching

## The headline feature nobody else offers

**0**
platforms that do
AI-powered open call matching

**75%**
acceptance rate for
early submitters (vs. 60% late)

**58→79%**
acceptance rate for
repeat submitters (4-10 subs)

### How It Works (B2C)

AI matches artist profiles to open calls based on medium, style, tags, location, career stage. The enriched data already exists in the system. Artists currently spend $200-500+/year on submission fees with zero matching intelligence — CaFE and Submittable host calls but don't match. This feature alone justifies Artist Pro at $15-20/mo.

Average artist spends 3-10 hours/year on repetitive submission data entry. Auto-matching eliminates this entirely.

THE DATA GAP

# Why Matching Needs Interviews

## Public research can't capture what matters most for matching

### What We Have Today

FROM PUBLIC RESEARCH (PERPLEXITY)

Bio, exhibition history, medium, style, education, gallery representation, social media presence, press mentions

### What Matching Actually Needs

FROM CONVERSATIONAL AI INTERVIEW

Venue preferences, shipping willingness, submission fee budget, geographic constraints, career ambitions, preferred exhibition scale, medium they *want* to be known for

The key insight: The AI interview isn't just a nicer onboarding experience — it's critical infrastructure for the matching engine. Preference data, intent data, and constraint data can't be scraped from the web. A 10-15 minute conversation during onboarding captures what no competitor can replicate with public research alone. This is the data moat.

THE B2B PLAY

# Open Call Matching for Galleries

## Not just artists — galleries and organizations as clients

**8-12K**
active open calls globally at any time

**5,700+**
call listings on CaFE alone annually

**0**
competitors offering roster-based matching

### Gallery Subscription

Gallery uploads roster of 20-50 artists. Platform scans 10,000+ calls and surfaces matches by medium, style, geography, career stage. Gallery offers this as a value-added service to their artists.

### Arts Orgs & Collectives

Arts councils (200-2,000 members), cooperatives, university art departments, nonprofit galleries. Matching as a member benefit across local → regional → national → international.

No one connects these two sides. CaFE, Submittable, ArtCall = submission infrastructure. ArtLogic, ARTERNAL = gallery CRM. Neither bridges the gap. Pricing: $99-299/mo per gallery. 500 subscribers at $149/mo avg = $894K ARR. Adjacent: ArtLogic charges $409-$1,690/mo for gallery CRM alone.

AI-POWERED INTERVIEWS

# Conversational AI as Platform Infrastructure

**COMPLETION RATE**

**70-90%** AI interview

**10-30%** traditional form

**RESPONSE DEPTH**

**2.5-8x** longer than forms

**COST PER INTERVIEW**

**$1-1.50** via Retell.ai

Use cases across the platform:

Artist onboarding — 10-15 min audio interview replaces forms, captures artistic philosophy, influences, career stage, exhibition goals. AI summarizes into structured Supabase fields.

Pricing validation — Conversational Van Westendorp study yields more honest responses than surveys.

B2B qualification — AI pre-filters high-value design/consultant prospects before human engagement.

Collector engagement — Preference discovery via dialogue, not checkboxes.

PHASED ROLLOUT

# AI Interview Implementation Path

### Phase 1

WEEKS 1-6 · $200-500

TheySaid or User Intuition for pricing study + smoke test interviews

### Phase 2

MONTHS 3-6 · $5-10K

Custom Retell.ai / Vapi.ai build for artist onboarding interviews

### Phase 3

MONTHS 6-12

B2B qualification interviews with Ribbon AI

### Phase 4

YEAR 2+

Hume AI emotional analysis layer for deeper artist profiling

Key insight: AI interviews aren't a separate product — they improve activities the platform already needs to do. The 90-day experiment calls for onboarding questions, a Van Westendorp survey, and 15-20 qualitative interviews. Conversational AI delivers higher quality at lower effort and cost for all three.

VALIDATION STRATEGY

# The $600 Smoke Test

Test before you build. 2-3 weeks.

**8-12%**
CTR
Strong product-market fit. Build the paid version.

**2-8%**
CTR
Proceed with caution. May work with iteration.

**<2%**
CTR
Rethink the model. Keep as lead magnet.

The 90-day experiment: Launch simple public gallery (weeks 1-2) → Gate contact behind signup (weeks 2-3) → Monitor engagement (weeks 3-4) → AI-powered Van Westendorp pricing study (weeks 4-5) → Smoke test with $300-600 ad spend (weeks 5-6) → Segment analysis (weeks 6-8) → AI qualitative interviews (weeks 8-9) → Synthesize and decide (weeks 9-12)

Day 90 decision: Signup >15% + any segment shows WTP of $5+/mo in both survey AND smoke test = build paid version. Strong engagement but weak WTP = keep as lead magnet. Signup <10%, time on site <2 min = rethink.

DISCUSSION

# Questions for Us

Is this a platform play or a feature of the existing ecosystem? Does it live on its own or enhance Arterial/NRA/Artsville?

Do we build for artists (the supply side) or for the people who buy from them (the demand side)? Where does the first dollar come from?

If open call matching is the killer feature — should the directory be the product, or should the matching engine be the product with the directory as the data layer?

What's the minimum viable test? Can we validate willingness to pay before writing a single line of code?